

Carry On, Mr. Bowdich

Chapter 8



CHAPTER 8



"LOCK, STOCK, AND BOOKKEEPER"

One Thursday late in October Hab appeared in the door of the chandlery. "Ahoy the ship!" he yelled. Grinning, he entered with the rolling walk of a man who is used to a pitching deck under his feet. After he had shaken hands and slapped Nat on the back, he said, "What's all the excitement in town? Soldiers all over the place! Flags flying and drums beating! How'd you guess I'd get home just now?"

Nat laughed with him, then said, "President Washington's touring the country. He'll be here today."

"Washington!" Hab's eyes glowed. "Am I lucky! You know, Nat, when a man's at sea, he doesn't know what's going on at home. Every time you get home, you feel like you'd been asleep for six months. How's everyone?"

Nat gave him news of home. Mary was fine, Lizza was prettier than ever, William was getting along fine in navigation school, Sammy was bright, but he wouldn't study. Lois had knitted a pair of socks all by herself.

"And Father?" Hab asked.

Nat shook his head. Father wasn't doing so well. "Granny was right; when Mother died, Father lost his anchor to windward."

For a moment Hab's face was grim. He sighed and shook off his mood. "How soon can you close the shop? Then we'll go together and see them."

"I'll have to ask Mr. Hodges." Nat told him.

"What!" Then Hab must have remembered, too, the words of the indenture. Nat could not leave by day or by night without permission. "When a man's on ship-board, it's *Aye, aye, sir* and you obey on the double. But at least when I'm in home port I'm my own boss!"

Mr. Hodges came to shake hands with Hab. He said, "Nat, go along with Hab if you'd like. I'll close up. You needn't be back until tomorrow morning."

Nat thanked him. Hab and Nat left the shop together and walked down the street through the milling crowds.

For a while they were silent. Then Hab remarked, "Mr. Hodges is mighty nice. But it's still like being in jail — being indentured!"

"I don't spend much time thinking about it," Nat said.

At one o'clock they joined the crowd that was forming on Court Street. The officers of the town were first, then the ministers, the merchants, the mechanics, and the schoolmasters with their students. They marched to the square near the entrance to Salem, and separated into two lines, leaving the roadway open between for the parade to pass. With a ruffle of drums and the shrilling

of fifes the soldiers passed: the Salem Regiment in their red coats and light trousers, the soldiers from Ipswich in blue, the Independents in red, and the Artillery in black. It seemed to Nat every regiment looked smarter, stood straighter, and marched better than the last one.

At last someone shouted the news; they had hoisted the flag at Gardiner's Mills, two miles from town. That was the signal that Washington and his party were passing there. After a while — faintly at first and then louder — came the shrilling of fifes and rat-a-tat-tat of the drums. He was coming!

Nat heard the voice of Colonel Abbot, of the Salem Regiment: "Attention!"

The fifes and drums grew louder. The troops from Andover appeared in their dashing red uniforms, every button shining, leather gleaming. The cannon roared a salute that shook the town. The church bells clanged. Then a great shout went up. For there was President Washington — a tall, commanding man, riding horseback to enter the town. His coach and baggage wagon followed behind them.

Nat didn't realize how he had been yelling and cheering until the president had passed, and the troops had fallen in behind him.

Hab croaked, "I almost split my throat!"

Nat tried to answer and found he was croaking, too.

That night Nat spent with his family, watching the fireworks at the courthouse.

The next day, Washington and his party went on to Ipswich. Soon, Hab sailed again. Then Nat's days and nights settled down once more to the steady grind of sailing by ash breeze — working all day in the chandlery, studying late every night. He was reading straight through Chambers' *Cyclopaedia* now.

"There's a little bit about everything in it," he told Dr. Bentley, "but every time I read a short article on something, I wish I had a whole book. For instance, astronomy. I'd like a whole book about that."

Dr. Bentley said, "Isaac Newton's *Principia* is the book for you. That tells more about the stars than anything else. I have a copy. I'm going to Boston for a few days, but I'll try to send that over before I leave." And he hurried out of the chandlery.

That afternoon a youngster brought Nat the copy of *Principia*. Nat was too busy even to open the book then, but all day as he worked he kept smiling to himself. That evening he hurried through his supper, went up to his room, and lighted a candle. Smiling, he opened the book. A whole book about astronomy!

Disappointed, he stared at it. He couldn't read a word. He could figure out just enough to know that the book was written in Latin. Then another idea struck Nat — how long would it take to learn Latin, so he could read *Principia*? When Dr. Bentley got back Saturday, he'd ask him.

But Nat couldn't wait that long to ask someone. The next day he asked a Harvard graduate he knew how long it would take to learn Latin.

"Latin?" Elias Wilson said. "It's mighty hard. All the time I was in school, I had nightmares over Latin."

Nat showed him the copy of *Principia*. "How long would I have to study Latin to read this?"

Mr. Wilson threw up his hands. "Enough Latin to read that? You'd need at least eight years, I'd say — under a good teacher!"

On Saturday Dr. Bentley dropped in at the chandlery.
“Well, Nat, how are you enjoying *Principia*?”

“It’s in Latin.”

“Of course.” Dr. Bentley smiled. “Latin is the language of scholars and scientists. Then they can all read each other’s books. A very handy language, isn’t it?”

“I suppose it is handy,” Nat said, “if you know it. But I don’t.”

Dr. Bentley stared. “Dear me, I never thought of that!”

“I wondered if I could learn Latin . . .” Nat said.

“Of course! The very thing! Come see me this evening, Nat.”

That evening Dr. Bentley said, “Here you are; a grammar, a dictionary and — by the way, do you know your Bible well?”

"Yes, sir, but it's in English."

Dr. Bentley chuckled. "It's in Latin, too, you know." He opened a New Testament in Latin. "Think of some passage you know well."

Nat repeated the opening verse of the Book of John: In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

Dr. Bentley showed him the same passage in Latin: *In principio erat Sermo ille, et Sermo ille erat apud Deum, eratque ille Sermo Deus.*

Nat said, "I've figured out three words already: *In* is just the same as our word; *principio* is 'beginning': *Sermo* is 'word.' "

Dr. Bentley nodded. "*Sermo* — that's where we get our word 'sermon.' " He smiled. "Oh, you won't have any trouble with Latin. Latin isn't hard. It's *Principia* that will be hard. It's hard to understand even when you can read it!"

Back in his own room; Nat stared at the Latin books. Could he do it? Well, he could try! One thing, he thought, if he ever got a chance to go to Harvard, he'd need to know Latin. Just now a chance to go to Harvard seemed farther away than ever. But, he told himself, you never could tell what might happen. If the chance came, he'd be ready.

By the next summer, he had learned enough Latin to begin to translate *Principia*. It seemed to him that he lived in two worlds now. One was the world of the chandlery, where he kept books and sold marlinespikes, belaying pins, and hemp rope. The other was the world of the universe, where he translated Newton's *Principia* — a word at a time, until he had read another sentence. Sometimes he spent a whole evening on two or three sentences.

There was another world, too — the world of Salem. Every time Nat went on an errand he realized how Salem was growing. The men of Salem were proud of their town. Their “city,” they called it now. Here it was — only 1790 — not even ten years since we’d won our independence — and Salem had doubled in size! Eight thousand people now! The people bragged of the growth of Salem, and of the daring of her sailors. Elias Hasket Derby’s ships were going farther and farther from their home port. As Nat shouldered his way

through the crowded wharves he heard talk of Russia and France and Spain, of Bombay and Calcutta.

One day he heard a chance remark that surprised him so much that he walked half a mile out of his way before he remembered where he was supposed to go.

"I hear Ropes and Hodges are selling the chandlery," a man remarked. "Samuel Ward is buying it."

"You sure?" the other man said.

"Well, I haven't seen the papers, but I heard . . . "

The men moved out of earshot.

Nat walked on in a daze. Ropes and Hodges selling out! His heart pounded until the blood drummed in his ears. At last! His chance was coming. When Ropes and Hodges sold the chandlery, he'd be free! He'd get to go to Harvard after all. Seventeen wasn't too old. Mr. Morris had said, "If in a year or two something happens and you're free" It had been just one year.

When Nat got back to the shop, Mr. Ropes was in the doorway. "You're back, Nat? Good. I've something to see about. I'll be gone about an hour. Then Jonathan and I have something to talk over with you." He smiled and was gone.

So it was true. Nat smiled, too. He went to his desk and started his letter to Mr. Morris:

. . . Since Ropes and Hodges are selling out, I'll be free of my indenture. I can come to Cambridge and tutor your children and study for Harvard. I've been studying Latin for a year now, so . . .

Nat heard someone enter the shop. He laid down his quill and stood. It was Samuel Ward — the man they said was buying the chandlery.

Mr. Ward smiled. "Don't bother about me, Nat. I just dropped in to look around. I don't know if you've heard it yet, but I'm buying the chandlery."

Nat grinned. "Congratulations, Mr. Ward. It's a fine chandlery."

Mr. Ward smiled, too. "And I'll get a fine bookkeeper with it, won't I? Yes, sir, I bought it — lock, stock, and bookkeeper."

Nat could feel the smile getting stiff on his face.

Mr. Ward didn't seem to notice. He chuckled at his own joke. "Lock, stock, and bookkeeper. That's pretty good, isn't it? Yes, Nat, I bought your indenture, right along with the cable and marline-spikes."

Nat forced himself to smile again. "That's right. I come with the rest of the supplies, don't I?" He picked up the letter to Mr. Morris and crushed it in his hand.

“What’s that? Some figuring?” Mr. Ward asked. “I hear you’re quite a hand with figures. I hope I didn’t interrupt a problem — and mix you up.”

“No,” Nat told him, “you didn’t interrupt anything. It was just a little problem. I know the answer now.” He crushed the paper into a hard wad and tossed it into the waste basket.

Yes, he knew the answer. The answer was — no freedom until he was twenty-one. Four more years in the chandlery. Then it would be too late for Harvard. He’d still have to sail by ash breeze.